

BOUNCING FORWARD

Companion Workbook

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INTRODUCTION

A Note Before You Begin

In January 2008, Maher Kaddoura's seventeen-year-old son Hikmat was killed in a hit-and-run in Amman. He turned that loss into the Hikmat Road Safety Programme—over 1,200 playgrounds built, 260 schools made safer, 1,800 dangerous road locations identified across Jordan. This workbook is built on what he learned. Not from books. From the inside of real loss.

You don't need to have read the main book to use this workbook. Each section explains the ideas behind it so the exercises mean something when you do them. Life doesn't always go according to plan. Loss, failure, and change can shake everything. This workbook won't take you back to who you were.

**“Not going back to who you were.
Going forward to who you are capable
of becoming.”**

How This Workbook Is Organised

This workbook gives you two tools.

The first is the 4-Element Framework—Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, and Support. Think of it as your compass. It doesn't tell you where you're going. It tells you which direction is forward—even when you can't see any distance at all.

The second is the 4-Step Model—Accept, Reflect, Imagine, Action. This is your path. One step at a time. One foot in front of the other, with intention rather than simply enduring.



At the back you'll find a full self-assessment—40 questions across all eight dimensions—with score guides to help you understand where you are and where your most important work lies. Take it before you begin as a starting map, or after working through the sections when you have more self-knowledge to draw on. Either way works.

How to Use This Workbook

Move through this workbook on your terms:

- ☐ Move at your own pace — there is no schedule
- ☐ Be honest, not impressive — no one will read this but you
- ☐ Skip sections that don't fit right now — and return later
- ☐ Return anytime — this is a companion, not a test

Your Grounding: Before You Begin

Beneath everything in this workbook — beneath the framework, the steps, the exercises — is one question: what holds you when everything moves? For Maher, it was faith. For others it is family, a deeply held value, a community, a philosophical conviction. You do not need to share his tradition. But this workbook asks you to name your own ground. What has held you in the past, when everything else shifted? It may be a person, a belief, a practice, a memory, or a sentence that keeps you tethered. Write it here, before you go any further:

What holds me:

Keep that answer somewhere close. It will carry more weight than any framework.

Part One

WHERE ARE YOU RIGHT NOW?

Taking your own temperature before you begin

PART 1: WHERE ARE YOU RIGHT NOW?

Before anything else, get honest about where you actually are. Not where you hope to be. Not where you think you should be. Where you genuinely are on an ordinary day when no one is watching. The exercises in this section aren't scored. They're simply a way of taking stock before you begin.

1.1 Your Current State

Right now, I feel: (Tick all that apply)

- ☐ Overwhelmed
 - ☐ Numb
 - ☐ Stuck
 - ☐ Searching for direction
 - ☐ Trying to rebuild
 - ☐ Moving forward slowly
 - ☐ Hopeful, even if slightly
 - ☐ Other:
-

1.2 What Are You Dealing With?

The main challenge I am carrying right now is: (Tick all that apply)

- ☐ Loss — a person, a relationship, an identity
 - ☐ Career or business setback
 - ☐ Health challenge
 - ☐ Financial pressure
 - ☐ Major life transition
 - ☐ Burnout or exhaustion
 - ☐ Uncertainty about the future
 - ☐ Other:
-

Rate yourself:

Low energy ☐ Full energy

Not ready to move ☐ Fully ready to move

1.3 One Honest Sentence

Complete this sentence before you continue:

If I am completely honest about where I am right now, I would say:

What you have just done — naming where you actually are, without softening it — is the only genuine starting point for the work ahead.

Not where you hope to be.

Not where you feel you should be.

Here.

That may seem like a small thing. It isn't. Everything that follows can only be useful to you if you are actually present — the version of you who exists right now, carrying what you are carrying. You have named that person. The rest follows from here.

Part Two

YOUR COMPASS

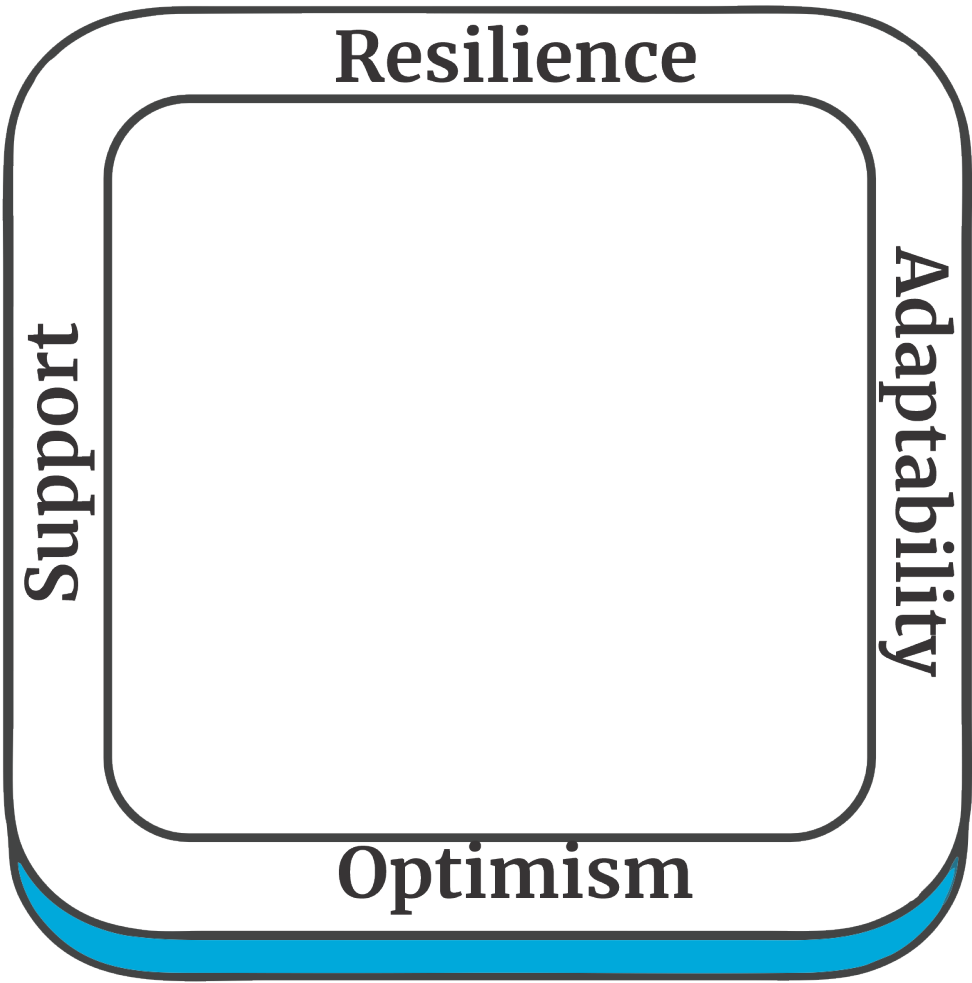
The 4-Element Framework

BOUNCING FORWARD

These four elements—Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, and Support—are always burning inside you. Even when they can’t be seen. They’re not a sequence to follow in order. They’re four aspects of the same capacity: your ability to find the direction of forward, whatever the terrain.

The work is to keep each light as bright as possible. Each section opens with an explanation of the element, a real-life example, questions for reflection, self-assessment exercises, and a bridge question to carry into the next section.

“They’re four aspects of the same capacity: your ability to find the direction of forward, whatever the terrain.”



Element one
RESILIENCE
Weathering the Storms of Adversity

If you’ve come straight to this section, you’re in exactly the right place. You may be in the middle of something hard right now, or still carrying the weight of something that happened some time ago. Either way, this section asks one thing of you: honesty. Not about how strong you are. About how you actually are. That’s where real resilience begins.

What This Means

Resilience is your capacity to keep going when things are hard. Not the performance of coping—the convincing display designed to reassure others that you’re managing. That version delays recovery. Real resilience is built by walking through difficulty at a sustainable pace, with eyes open.

Think of bamboo in a storm. It bends almost parallel to the ground under fierce wind. When the storm passes, it slowly returns upright. No drama. No performance. Just the deep structural knowledge that bending is not breaking.

“Not the performance of coping—the convincing display designed to reassure others that you’re managing.”

Resilience is built, not born. It grows through five honest practices: allowing grief to be grief rather than rushing past it; finding the one sentence that anchors you when nothing else does; letting people in rather than carrying everything alone; asking “what can this become?” rather than stopping at “why did this happen?”; and remembering—with intention—what you’ve already survived. That last one matters most. You’re here. Every difficult thing that has ever come for you has not had the final word. That is evidence. Let it be evidence.

A note of caution

Before you tell someone you’re fine, ask yourself honestly whether you actually are. Performed resilience—managing impressively for others while struggling privately—delays real recovery. If that gap exists in you, it’s worth paying attention to.

A Real-Life Example: Malala Yousafzai

In 2012, fifteen-year-old Malala Yousafzai was shot in the head on a school bus in Pakistan for advocating girls’ education. She survived. When she was well enough to speak, she did not choose silence — she chose amplification. “They thought that the bullets would silence us. But they failed.” That is resilience in its fullest expression: not merely surviving what was aimed at your destruction, but using the fact of your survival as the source of your power.

Reflect

When was the last time you turned a failure into a stepping stone? What did you learn about yourself in the process?

Have you ever felt like giving up but didn’t? What kept you going, and how did you feel when you came out the other side?

Think of the hardest thing you have already survived. You did not know, in the middle of it, that you would come through — but you did. What carried you?

Self-Assessment

When things go wrong, I usually:

- ☐ Shut down or withdraw
- ☐ Push through but struggle internally
- ☐ Adapt and keep moving
- ☐ Look for meaning or lessons

What helps me keep going (tick up to three):

- ☐ Faith or belief
- ☐ Family
- ☐ Friends
- ☐ Discipline
- ☐ Purpose
- ☐ Past experience of surviving
- ☐ Routine
- ☐ Other:

Rate yourself:

[illegible]

The one sentence practice

One of the most powerful resilience tools is finding the single sentence that holds you — not because it explains the pain, but because it anchors you to something larger than it. For Maher, in his darkest moments, it was ‘Praise be to God.’ Not because he felt grateful. Because it kept him tethered. Your sentence doesn’t need to be religious. It might be a line from a poem, a truth you know about yourself, a commitment to someone you love. It only needs to be yours. Write it here:

My anchoring sentence:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Remind myself of one specific thing I have already survived. Let it be evidence.
- ☐ Reach out to one person — not to fix anything, just to connect.
- ☐ Allow myself to feel what I am feeling today, without immediately trying to fix it.
- ☐ Say my anchoring sentence once, slowly, before I get out of bed tomorrow.

You have just done something that takes more courage than it looks like from the outside. You sat with questions about how you actually hold up under difficulty — not the version you present to others, but the one that exists on an ordinary morning when no one is watching.

The most important thing this section asks you to carry is not a technique. It is this: you have already survived things that, in the middle of them, you did not know you would survive. That is not a small fact. It is evidence — and evidence, accumulated honestly over time, is what resilience is actually built from.

Your anchoring sentence is yours now. Keep it close. Not as an answer to the pain. As a tether to something larger than it.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Adaptability: given what you just discovered about your resilience — what you lean on, where you struggle, what has held you before — what does that tell you about how you approach change?

Element Two

ADAPTABILITY

Navigating the Rapids of Change

You may be facing a version of yourself that no longer quite fits — or resisting the idea that it needs to change. Both are honest places to be. This section is not about becoming someone else. It is about finding the most honest way to keep being yourself in circumstances that have, without your permission, shifted. You don’t need to have read anything before this to work through Adaptability. If this element speaks directly to you, start here.

What This Means

Adaptability is your willingness to adjust — deliberately, with intention — when life changes. It is the decision to dance with change rather than be swept away by it. Think of your mind as a smartphone: every so often, the operating system needs an update, not because the old version was broken, but because the world it operates in has changed. Adaptability is the willingness to update.

Loss doesn’t just take a person or a situation from you — it takes a version of yourself. The shape of who you were before may no longer fit. This is not a failure. It is an invitation to discover who you are capable of becoming.

“Follow what still stirs something in you, however faint that flicker.”

Five principles guide genuine adaptation: allow your identity to shift rather than forcing yourself back into a shape that no longer fits; follow what still stirs something in you, however faint that flicker; let the first attempt be imperfect; be patient with your own timeline; and deliberately keep one new door ajar that was not open before. You cannot know yet which door leads where. That is not a problem. It is the nature of beginning.

A caution about adapting too quickly

Adaptability is not the same as moving on. A capacity to adapt quickly can sometimes help you move past things before you have properly sat with them. Speed is not always the same thing as progress. As you work through this section, check that your adaptation is serving your healing, not helping you bypass it.

A Real-Life Example: Graça Machel

When Graça Machel’s husband — the founder of modern Mozambique — was killed in a plane crash in 1986, the world expected her to step back. Instead, she founded a development organisation, accepted a UN appointment to investigate the impact of armed conflict on children, and spent two years in conflict zones gathering testimony. Her 1996 report created a protection for children that still operates today. She did not adapt by becoming someone new. She adapted by becoming more fully herself.

Reflect

When have you thrived in a situation where others struggled? What does that tell you about your capacity to adapt?

Have you ever changed a strongly held belief because of a new experience? What changed your mind, and what did that feel like?

What from your previous life still fits who you are now? And what may no longer fit — however hard that is to admit?

Self-Assessment

When life changes, I usually:

- ☐ Resist — I prefer things to stay the same
- ☐ Accept it slowly, with difficulty
- ☐ Adapt when I have no choice
- ☐ Actively look for new directions

What has changed for you since the loss or setback? (Tick all that apply)

- ☐ My sense of identity
- ☐ My priorities
- ☐ My relationships
- ☐ My goals
- ☐ My daily routine

Rate yourself:

[illegible]

The imperfect first attempt

One of the most freeing ideas in this entire framework is this: the identity and direction you build after loss will not be correct on the first try. That is not failure — that is how rebuilding works. The willingness to try a shape that doesn't fit, and adjust, is itself the practice of adaptability. Name one small new thing you could try this week — something you would not normally do, something you have been putting off because it doesn't feel ready yet:

I will try:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Try one small new thing — something I would not normally do.
- ☐ Name one thing I am holding onto that no longer serves who I am now.
- ☐ Have one conversation I have been avoiding.
- ☐ Accept, just for today, that things are different — and that different is not the same as worse.

Working through these questions asks something specific of you: the willingness to look at what you are holding onto, and ask whether it still fits who you actually are now. That is not a comfortable question. It is, however, a necessary one.

The insight at the center of this element is worth carrying clearly: adjusting after loss is not a betrayal of what came before.

What you are being asked to update is not your values, not your love, not what matters most to you. It is only the shape in which you carry those things. That shape can change. Sometimes it must. That is not failure. It is how the journey continues.

You named one small thing you are willing to try. Let it be imperfect. Let it be the beginning.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Optimism: given what you know about how you adapt — where you resist, where you flex — what does that suggest about how you currently see the future?

Element Three

OPTIMISM

Lighting the Path Through the Darkness

Optimism may feel right now like a language you’ve partially forgotten—or one that seems almost dishonest given what you’re carrying. Both reactions make sense. Neither disqualifies you from working through this. This section isn’t going to ask you to feel hopeful. It’s going to ask you to observe—very quietly—what is still working. That’s where genuine optimism begins. Not in feeling. In noticing.

What This Means

Here’s something the optimism literature rarely admits: being optimistic is hard. Pessimism is effortless. Your brain is designed for it—the human nervous system evolved to detect threat, anticipate danger, and catalogue everything that could go wrong. Optimism requires active, daily effort. It’s a practice, not a personality type. Optimism, as this framework understands it, is not pretending the forest is a meadow. It’s choosing to believe there is a way through. And crucially—you don’t have to feel optimistic to practise it.

Begin by observing, not by feeling. What today did not break me? What small thing still worked? What moment, even briefly, carried some quality of light? That observation is where optimism begins. Forced positivity is a performance. This is different.

“Optimism requires active, daily effort. It’s a practice, not a personality type.”

One distinction is worth carrying everywhere: “this is how I feel today” is not the same sentence as “this is who I am,” or “this is how it will always be.” Setbacks have a way of making the present feel permanent. It isn’t. Practice separating the two.

A note of caution

There is a difference between genuine optimism and performed cheerfulness. The instinct to find the silver lining too soon after a loss can be a way of bypassing a setback rather than building through it. If optimism feels out of reach right now, that is an honest response to an honest situation — not a character flaw. Start with observation, not with feeling.

A Real-Life Example: Immaculée Ilibagiza

In 1994, Immaculée Ilibagiza survived Rwanda’s genocide by hiding in a pastor’s bathroom — three feet by four feet, with seven other women — for ninety-one days. Her mother, father, and two brothers were killed. During those ninety-one days, she made a decision, not once but every single day, to believe that something worth living for still existed on the other side. She emerged weighing sixty-five pounds. She went on to work at the United Nations and write her story, which has been read by millions. That is not naivety. That is optimism in its most demanding form.

Reflect

When everything seems to be going against you, how do you find something — however small — that keeps you moving forward?

Can you recall a moment when your attitude — the choice you made about how to hold a situation — changed the outcome?

What is one thing that is still working in your life, however small? What is one moment from the past week that carried some quality of light?

Self-Assessment

When I think about my situation and future, my thinking tends to be:

- ☐ Mostly negative — it is hard to see a way through
- ☐ Mixed — up and down depending on the day
- ☐ Mostly hopeful, even if uncertain
- ☐ Forward-focused — I can see a direction

What pulls me down most? (Tick up to two):

- ☐ Fear of failure
- ☐ Overthinking
- ☐ Past experiences replaying
- ☐ Lack of clarity about the future
- ☐ Comparing myself to others

Rate yourself:

Low Optimism ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ High Optimism

The observation practice

You cannot command yourself to feel optimistic. But you can train yourself to notice. For the next seven days, write one answer each evening to this question: What happened today that did not break me? It does not need to be significant. A moment of warmth. A task completed. A conversation that held. These small observations are the building blocks of genuine optimism — because over time, you begin to see the pattern: you are still here, and something is still working. Start tonight:

Today, what did not break me:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ At the end of today, name one thing that did not break me.
- ☐ Challenge one dark thought: ask whether it is actually true — or just familiar.
- ☐ Find one person who has carried something like what I am carrying, and come through.
- ☐ Take one positive action connected to something I care about.

If some of these questions felt difficult—if hope felt more like an effort than a natural response—that is not a character flaw. It’s an honest reaction to an honest situation.

Carry this distinction clearly: “this is how I feel today” is not the same sentence as “this is how it will always be.” Loss and setbacks have a way of making the present feel permanent. It isn’t. The practice of noticing—one small thing that did not break you—is how you begin, slowly and without forcing it, to understand that.

Start today. One thing. That is enough.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Support: your optimism level affects how you receive help. If you believe things can improve, you are more likely to let people in. What does your current optimism level tell you about how you’ve been approaching the people around you?

Element Four

SUPPORT

Weaving a Net of Collective Strength

If you feel like you’re carrying your burden alone, this is a good place to start. You may be carrying more alone than you need to—or you may be someone who gives readily to others but finds it difficult to receive. Both are common, and both are worth examining here. Support isn’t something you wait for. It’s something you build—in both directions—long before the hardest moments arrive.

What This Means

Support is not just who helps you. It’s who you allow in. No one crosses any significant journey alone. Every great transformation is made possible by someone who stood beside the traveller when they could not stand alone. Support flows in both directions, or it does not flow at all. The network that can hold you in your worst moments is not built after crisis arrives—it is built in the ordinary, quiet days before it.

Research confirms what experience tells us: strong social ties boost immune function, reduce stress, and are among the most powerful predictors of recovery from loss.

“Support is not just who helps you. It’s who you allow in.”

Setbacks create a powerful pull toward isolation—the feeling that your pain is too heavy to ask others to bear. That feeling is almost always wrong, and it is almost always harmful. The people around you do not need to understand your setback perfectly to offer something useful. Presence alone is a form of support. Let one person in.

A note of caution

If you feel that your pain is too much to ask anyone to carry, that feeling deserves gentleness — but not agreement. The people who love you do not need to understand your setback perfectly. They only need to be present. Do not let the pursuit of perfect understanding stop you from accepting imperfect, genuine human company. Let one person in. Not everyone — one person.

A Real-Life Example: Abdul Sattar Edhi

Abdul Sattar Edhi began with a single room in Karachi in the 1950s and almost nothing else. Over the following decades, he built an infrastructure of care — ambulances, orphanages, shelters — that touched millions of lives. His wife Bilquis's steady, unglamorous daily support gave him the platform from which everything was built. "No religion is higher than humanity." The support web is built in the quiet seasons. It holds you in the storms.

Reflect

Think of a time when someone's support changed the direction of your life. What would have happened without it?

Who is your unsung hero — the person who always shows up for you? Have you told them what that means?

Is there someone in your life right now who has been trying to support you, whom you have been keeping at arm's length? What would it mean to let them in?

Self-Assessment

When I am struggling, I tend to:

- ☐ Handle it alone — asking for help is hard
- ☐ Rely on one or two people, but cautiously
- ☐ Have a small support network I draw on
- ☐ Actively seek support — I know it helps

Who do I have? (Tick all that apply):

- ☐ Family
- ☐ Friends
- ☐ A mentor or coach
- ☐ A community (faith, interest, local)
- ☐ At the moment, no one I truly rely on

Rate yourself:

[illegible]

A thank-you that is overdue

Research consistently shows that expressing gratitude — specifically and directly — strengthens social bonds and improves both the giver's and receiver's wellbeing. Identify one person in your life who showed up for you during a difficult time and whom you have not properly thanked. Their name:

What they did that mattered:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Send a message to one person — just to connect, not to explain everything.
- ☐ Ask for one specific kind of help. Be honest about what you actually need.
- ☐ Spend time with someone this week — presence, not problem-solving.
- ☐ Offer support to someone else. Giving opens the same door as receiving.

Looking honestly at who you have—and at how willing you are to actually let them in—is harder than it sounds. Setbacks pull strongly toward isolation. Its logic seems reasonable: if I don’t ask, I won’t be a burden. This section asked you to examine that logic directly. It deserves examination.

The most important thing to carry from here is simple: the people around you do not need to understand your pain perfectly in order to help you bear it. Presence is enough. One person, one honest conversation, is a sufficient beginning. Before you move on—whose name came to mind while you worked through this section? That is not a coincidence. That is the answer.

Before you continue →

Before moving to the 4-Step Model: looking at all four elements — Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, Support — which feels most alive in you right now? Which feels most depleted? Keep both answers in mind as you work through the steps ahead.

You have now worked through all four elements of the compass — or the ones that mattered most to you today. Either way, you have done something worth pausing on: you have taken an honest reading of where your lights are burning, and where they may need tending.

The compass, remember, does not tell you where you are going. It tells you which direction is forward — even when the terrain is difficult and the distance is invisible. Each element — your resilience, your willingness to adapt, your capacity for hope, the people around you — is a light you can deliberately tend. None of them needs to be blazing for you to move. They only need to be lit.

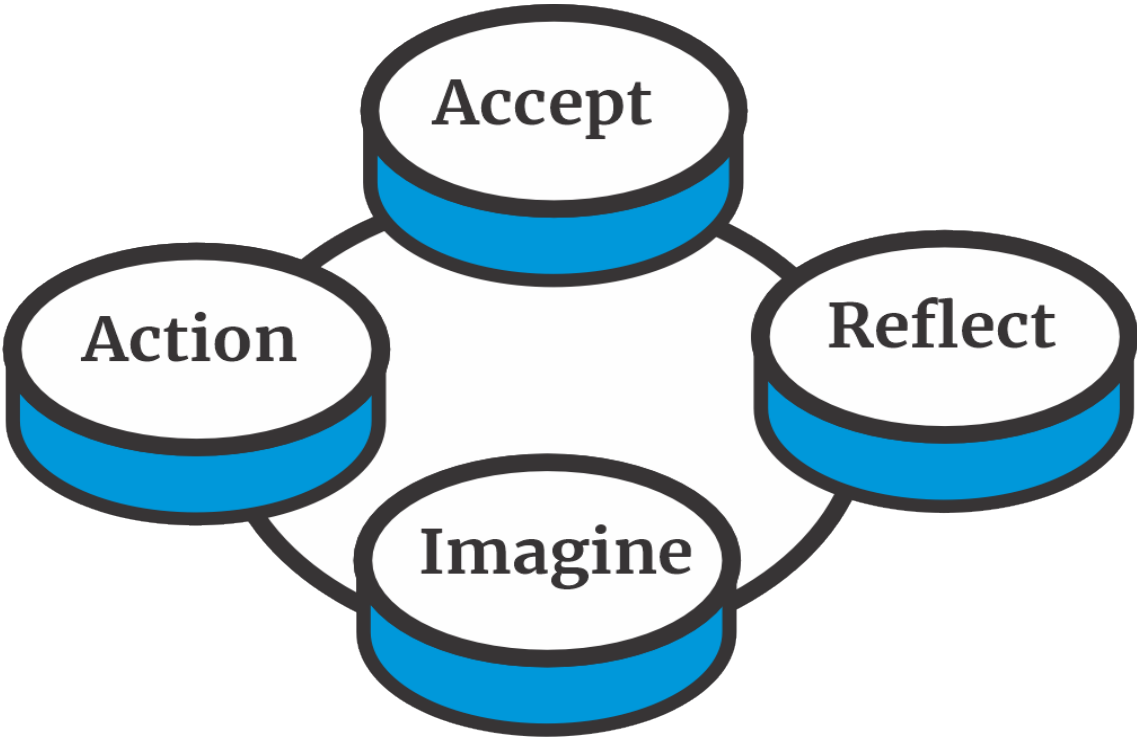
Take what you discovered with you. Not as a verdict on where you are, but as a map of where the most important work lies. The path is ahead.

If the 4-Element Framework is your compass — telling you which direction is forward — then the 4-Step Model is your path. It traces four steps: Accept, Reflect, Set Goals, and Take Action. They are not a formula. Life does not move in straight lines, and setbacks least of all.

But they are motion: a way of putting one foot in front of the other with intention, rather than simply enduring. You do not need to complete one perfectly before moving to the next — but you do need to have honestly begun it. The goal is progress, not performance.

“The goal is progress, not performance.”

Part Three
YOUR PATH
The 4-Step Model



Step One

ACCEPT

Embracing the Inevitable

If you have come directly to this step, something has happened that you are still — in some way — finding difficult to face. That is not a weakness. It is what honest acknowledgment actually feels like before it becomes acceptance. This step does not ask you to feel at peace with what happened. It asks only that you begin to name it as real. That is all. That is enough.

What This Means

Acceptance is not surrender. It is the bridge between who you were before the loss and who you are still capable of becoming. It means acknowledging the full truth of what happened — that it was real, that it mattered, and that it will not change — while refusing to let that truth be the last word about your life. There is a particular trap that setbacks set: the labyrinth of ‘what if.’ What if I had been somewhere else? What if things had gone differently?

These questions are natural, and they deserve compassion. But they are also a way of refusing to accept the one truth that matters: the sequence of events is what it was. Every moment spent in the what-if is a moment not present in the only time available — now.

“Acceptance is not surrender. It is the bridge between who you were before the loss and who you are still capable of becoming.”

The shift that acceptance makes possible is a shift in question: from ‘why did this happen?’ — which has no answer — to ‘who am I, carrying this, going forward?’ — which demands one. That shift is not a betrayal of what was lost. It is where acceptance begins to become something useful.

Acceptance is not the same as approval

Accepting a loss does not mean agreeing that it should have happened, or that it was fair, or that you are at peace with it. It means acknowledging that it did happen, and that the only territory available to you begins from here. You can accept a reality while still finding it unjust. That tension is not a contradiction — it is the truth of most significant losses.

A Real-Life Example: Nelson Mandela

When Nelson Mandela walked out of Victor Verster Prison in 1990 after twenty-seven years of incarceration, reporters expected a man consumed by righteous fury. Instead, they found a man at peace — one who had accepted not merely his own suffering, but the necessity of transforming it into something that could serve a future larger than himself. “As I walked out the door toward freedom, I knew if I didn’t leave my bitterness and hatred behind, I’d still be in prison.” Acceptance, in its fullest form, is an act of freedom.

Reflect

What is the specific thing about your loss that is hardest to accept — not the loss itself, but one particular aspect of it? The what-if you cannot release, the unfairness that still burns?

How has accepting a difficult reality — at any point in your life — changed your approach to what followed?

What would it mean to shift from the question ‘why did this happen?’ to ‘who am I, carrying this, going forward?’ What becomes possible with that shift?

Self-Assessment

Right now, I am:

- ☐ Avoiding the reality — it is too hard to face
- ☐ Partially accepting — some days I face it, some days I don’t
- ☐ Accepting, but finding it deeply painful
- ☐ Accepting, and beginning to find a way to carry it

What I struggle most to accept: (Tick all that apply)

- ☐ What happened
- ☐ Why it happened
- ☐ That it will not change
- ☐ What it means for my future

Rate yourself:

Deeply resisting

☐

☐

☐

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Carrying it

The daily practice of acceptance

Acceptance is not a single moment. It is a daily practice. Once each day, say to yourself — silently or aloud — one thing that is true about your loss, without immediately following it with a qualification or a comfort. This happened. It was real. It is part of my life now. The act of naming it, without softening it, is the practice. You do not have to do anything else with it. Today, the one true thing I can name is:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Say one true thing about my loss to myself — without immediately softening it.
- ☐ Let go of one ‘what if’ for today. Not forever. Just today.
- ☐ Focus on one thing I can actually do or change, however small.
- ☐ Take one step forward — however small, however imperfect.

What you have worked through here is not a small thing. Acceptance — the real kind, not the performed kind — asks you to hold a truth that every instinct may be working against: this happened, it will not change, and the only time available to you begins from here.

The most important insight in this step is a shift in question. The question with no answer is why did this happen? The question that demands one is who am I, carrying this, going forward? That second question does not require that you have stopped grieving. It only requires that you have stopped waiting for the grief to end before you begin.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Reflect: acceptance and reflection work together. You can only learn from what you are willing to acknowledge. What you have accepted about your situation — what you have named as true — is now the material for reflection. What is the most important truth you are taking into the next step?

Step Two

REFLECT

Uncovering Insights from Setbacks

This step is a good place to start if you’re sitting with an experience you haven’t yet found the words—or the stillness—to fully examine. You don’t need a system or a journaling practice to work through this section. You need one honest question and the willingness to stay with it a little longer than feels comfortable. That is the whole of what reflection asks.

What This Means

Reflection is not journaling in the traditional sense. It is not a quiet cup of tea with your thoughts. Reflection is the disciplined, sometimes uncomfortable practice of letting experience become wisdom—of sitting with what has happened until it tells you something true and useful about where you need to go next. There is a critical distinction worth knowing before you begin: reflection is not the same as rumination. Rumination asks the same questions repeatedly with no expectation of an answer—it circles the wound without treating it.

Reflection asks: what is this experience teaching me? And it looks for an answer that can inform what comes next. If you find yourself returning to the same thoughts without arriving anywhere new—that is rumination, not reflection. It may be time to bring a trusted person into the conversation.

“Reflection is the disciplined, sometimes uncomfortable practice of letting experience become wisdom.”

The question that turns reflection from a backward glance into a direction is this: not why did this happen, but—what does this ask of me? That question is where Maher’s grief became Hikmat’s legacy. It is where loss becomes direction.

A note of caution

If you notice that your reflection keeps returning to the same territory without moving, that is a signal, not a failure. It may mean the question needs to change, or that you need another person in the room with you. Reflection is not always a solo practice. Bring someone you trust into the conversation.

A Real-Life Example: Gandhi’s Day of Silence

Once a week, Mahatma Gandhi did not speak. In the middle of leading one of the most consequential political movements in modern history, he considered one day in seven too valuable a price not to pay for clarity. He observed a weekly day of silence as a practice of self-examination — a deliberate pause in which to assess what he had done, recalibrate his thinking, and ensure that his next actions would be more aligned with his values. You do not need a full day. Start with twenty minutes. Sit with your week. What happened? What did I learn? What do I want to do differently?

Reflect

What moments in your life have led to the most significant personal realisations? What conditions made that clarity possible?

Is there an experience from the past year that you have been moving past rather than sitting with? What might it be trying to tell you?

If you asked yourself ‘what does this loss or difficulty ask of me?’ — and you had to answer honestly — what would you say?

Self-Assessment

When something hard happens, I tend to:

- ☐ Avoid thinking about it — I prefer to move on
- ☐ Think about it sometimes, but not systematically
- ☐ Reflect when I really need to
- ☐ Reflect regularly — it is a genuine practice for me

From what I have been through, I have already found (tick what applies, even if incomplete):

- ☐ Greater strength than I knew I had
- ☐ A clearer sense of what matters
- ☐ More patience — with myself or others
- ☐ A different perspective on what I had before
- ☐ Nothing yet — it is still too early

Rate yourself:

[illegible]

The single question practice

If formal reflection feels too large to begin, reduce it to one question. At the end of one day this week, sit quietly for ten minutes and ask yourself: What did I feel today that I did not say out loud? Write the answer down, or simply sit with it. You do not need a journal, a system, or a dedicated hour. You need one honest question, answered honestly. That is the beginning of reflection.

One question to focus reflection this week — choose one:

- ☐ “What did I feel this week that I did not say out loud?”
- ☐ “What actually matters now — not what I thought mattered before?”
- ☐ “What does this experience ask of me going forward?”
- ☐ “What do I want next — honestly, underneath everything else?”

Sitting with experience long enough to let it tell you something—rather than moving past it because the stillness is uncomfortable—takes a particular kind of patience with yourself. If some of these questions felt difficult to stay with, that is usually a sign you were sitting close to something true.

The distinction at the heart of this step is worth carrying clearly: reflection is not the same as rumination. Rumination circles. Reflection moves. The question that makes the difference is not “why did this happen?” but “what does this ask of me?” That second question is the one that turns experience into direction.

You chose a question to carry this week. Let it work on you quietly. The answers that matter most rarely arrive all at once.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Set Goals: reflection without direction is rumination. You have sat with your experience — now the question shifts. Based on what you have learned about yourself through this workbook so far, what is the one thing most clearly asking to be different?

Step Three

IMAGINE

Defining the Path Forward

You may be at a point where what you’ve been carrying is starting to look less like a wall and more like a question: what now? You don’t need a grand plan. You don’t need certainty, or a clear vision of the future. You need one honest direction—something small and meaningful that gives the next day a shape. That is enough to begin with.

What This Means

At some point in crossing a forest, you look up. You’ve been so focused on the immediate—the next step, the next obstacle—that you haven’t lifted your eyes to the horizon. And when you do, and you see through a gap in the canopy the distant peak of a mountain catching the morning light, something changes. Not the forest—it is exactly as dense and difficult as before. What changes is your relationship to it. You are no longer simply moving. You are moving toward something specific.

A goal does not need to be large or distant to be useful. After loss, the idea of goals can feel premature—even inappropriate. That feeling is worth honouring. But a goal can simply be a direction: something small and meaningful that gives the next day a shape. Let the goal be small enough to start today.

“Whose face is attached to this goal? Who are you building this for, beyond yourself?”

The goals that sustain people through the hardest chapters of their lives are not merely practical. They are connected to what they care about most. Which is why there is one question that this framework asks every person who reaches this step: “Whose face is attached to this goal? Who are you building this for, beyond yourself?” That question is where goals gain the power to outlast difficulty. When Maher committed to making Jordan’s roads safer, Hikmat’s face was attached to every step. That connection transformed a practical ambition into something that could not be abandoned.

SMART + Purpose: use both

Use the SMART framework if it helps: make your goal Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. But before you do, ask the deeper question: what is this for? Whose face is attached to it? A SMART goal with purpose behind it becomes something no framework alone can give you: a goal that holds when things get hard.

A Real-Life Example: Chido Govera

When Chido Govera was seven years old, her mother died of AIDS in Zimbabwe, leaving her as the sole provider for her brother and grandmother. At eight, she made herself a promise: when I am older, I will make sure no other orphan has to live the way I am living. That was her goal — unwritten, but specific, and entirely her own. By sixteen she was earning enough to send her brother to school. She went on to found The Future of Hope Foundation, training over two thousand people across five countries to grow food from agricultural waste. She named her goal at eight years old, in grief, with nothing. Everything else followed from that.

Reflect

What is one goal you have held in the past that aligned with something you truly cared about? What made it feel different from other goals?

If you could name one thing you want to be different in your life six months from now — one concrete, honest thing — what would it be?

Whose face is attached to what you are trying to build? Who are you doing this for, beyond yourself?

Self-Assessment

Right now, when I think about the future:

- ☐ I have no clear direction — it is hard to think about the future at all
- ☐ I have some ideas, but nothing clear yet
- ☐ I have one clear goal I am working toward
- ☐ I have several goals — the challenge is focus, not clarity

What matters most to me now (tick up to two):

- ☐ Stability — a solid foundation to stand on
- ☐ Growth — becoming more than I was
- ☐ Purpose — something worth building
- ☐ Financial security
- ☐ Health — physical or mental
- ☐ Relationships — connection and belonging

Rate yourself:

No direction

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Clear direction

Write your goal here

In one sentence: the one thing I want to be different in six months. Not a plan — a direction. Not a resolution — a commitment.

My Goal:

Whose face is attached to this goal?

Why does this matter — beyond the practical?

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Say one true thing about my loss to myself — without immediately softening it.
- ☐ Let go of one ‘what if’ for today. Not forever. Just today.
- ☐ Focus on one thing I can actually do or change, however small.
- ☐ Take one step forward — however small, however imperfect.

What you have worked through here is not a small thing. Acceptance — the real kind, not the performed kind — asks you to hold a truth that every instinct may be working against: this happened, it will not change, and the only time available to you begins from here.

The most important insight in this step is a shift in question. The question with no answer is why did this happen? The question that demands one is who am I, carrying this, going forward? That second question does not require that you have stopped grieving. It only requires that you have stopped waiting for the grief to end before you begin.

Before you continue →

Before moving to Take Action: a goal without action is a wish. You have named your direction. The only question now is: what is the smallest real thing you can do in the next 24 hours that moves you even one inch toward it?

Step Four

ACTION

Catalysing Change Through Initiative

If you have come directly to this step, you may already have made progress—but you may have been finding reasons not to begin taking action. This step has one central message: the conditions will never be perfect. The readiness you are waiting for will not arrive before you start. It arrives because you start. The first step does not need to be large. It needs to be real.

What This Means

Turning a vision into reality demands action. Not perfect action. Not fearless action. Just the next step, taken. You will never feel completely ready. The conditions will never be right. Setbacks, in particular, have a way of making everything feel premature—it is too soon, I am not strong enough, I do not know enough yet. Begin anyway. The doing creates the readiness that waiting never will. The first step does not need to be large. It only needs to be real.

There is a distinction worth carrying into this step: passion inspires, but discipline delivers. The energy of purpose—setbacks transformed into fuel, the face attached to the goal—is what gets you out of bed on the hardest mornings.

“The doing creates the readiness that waiting never will.”

But it is the unglamorous daily work, the thousandth small decision, that builds something that lasts. Passion without discipline produces bursts. Discipline without passion produces burnout. Together, they build a legacy.

A note of caution

Setbacks can produce a particular kind of frantic activity — filling every hour, committing to every project, staying in constant motion — that looks like action but is actually avoidance. True action is purposeful: it is connected to the goal, which is connected to the reflection, which is connected to the loss. Every so often, stop and ask: what is this for? If the doing is disconnected from the meaning, it will exhaust you without building anything.

A Real-Life Example: Dr. Izzeldin Abuelaish

In January 2009, four months after his wife died of leukaemia, Dr. Izzeldin Abuelaish was on a live phone call to an Israeli television station when tank shells struck his home. Three of his daughters were killed. His screams were broadcast. What came next was his choice: he did not seek revenge. He accepted a fellowship at the University of Toronto, gathered his five surviving children, and founded the Daughters for Life Foundation — offering scholarships to girls and women across the Middle East, Palestinian and Israeli alike. His book *I Shall Not Hate* has been translated into twenty-three languages. Grief provided the reason. Discipline provided everything else.

Reflect

What small, actionable step could you take today — in the next hour — to move one inch closer to your goal?
What has been stopping you from taking it?

Think of a time when beginning imperfectly led somewhere better than waiting for the right moment would have. What did that teach you?

How do you maintain motivation when your actions don't seem to be producing results yet? What has sustained you in the past?

Self-Assessment

When I have a goal or intention, I tend to:

- ☐ Delay starting — I wait for the right moment
- ☐ Start, but lose momentum quickly
- ☐ Take action sometimes, but inconsistently
- ☐ Take consistent action — this is a genuine strength

What stops me? (Tick all that apply):

- ☐ Fear of failing or doing it wrong
- ☐ Lack of clarity about what to do
- ☐ Low energy — the tank is empty
- ☐ Perfectionism — if I can't do it right, I won't start
- ☐ Distractions — busyness without direction

Rate yourself:

[illegible]

Celebrate what no one else can see

The most important milestones in your journey are invisible to everyone else. The first morning you woke and felt, briefly, something other than the setback. The day you said the name of your loss in a room full of people and kept your voice steady. The moment the work you were building felt — for a second — like it belonged to the future rather than only to the past. These internal victories are not visible to anyone else. Mark them anyway. They are the foundation of everything that follows. One internal victory I have had recently that no one else knows about:

One action for this week — choose one:

- ☐ Do one thing in the next ten minutes — however small, however imperfect.
- ☐ Remove one obstacle that has been blocking my first step.
- ☐ Tell one person what I am trying to do. Say it out loud.
- ☐ Celebrate one internal victory that no one else can see — and let it count.

You have arrived at the end of the path—the point where everything this workbook has asked of you becomes something you actually do. The questions you sat with, the truths you named, the goal you wrote down: none of it carries weight until it becomes action. Not perfect action. Not fearless action. Just the next step, taken.

The thing most worth carrying from this step is the difference between passion and discipline. Setbacks tend to give people one without the other. The purpose behind your goal is what gets you moving on the hardest mornings. The daily, unglamorous work is what builds something that lasts. You need both, and you are building both. The internal victory you named—the one no one else can see—is real. Mark it. And then take the next step. The work is yours now.

You have now worked through all four steps of the path—Accept, Reflect, Set Goals, and Take Action. Whether you followed them in sequence or entered at the step that was most pressing today, you have covered the essential distance: from naming what is true, to understanding what it is asking of you, to knowing where you are going, to beginning to move.

The path does not end here. It extends forward into everything the action plan will ask you to commit to, and into every day you choose to return to this workbook and take stock. What changes, as you work through these steps and come back to them over time, is not the difficulty of what you are carrying. It is your relationship to it.

You are no longer simply enduring. You are moving with intention, toward something you have named, for someone whose face you have identified. That is not a small thing. That is the whole of what Bouncing Forward asks.

Part Four

YOUR SNAPSHOT

Pulling it all together

Now that you have worked through all eight dimensions, take a moment to get an overview of where you are. This is not a score to be proud of or ashamed of. It is a map of the terrain as it currently stands.

4.1 Your Strongest Areas

Circle the two or three where you feel most resourced right now:

- ☐ Resilience
- ☐ Adaptability
- ☐ Optimism
- ☐ Support
- ☐ Acceptance
- ☐ Reflection
- ☐ Goal-Setting
- ☐ Action

4.2 Your Areas for Development

Circle the two or three where the most important work currently lies:

- ☐ Resilience
- ☐ Adaptability
- ☐ Optimism
- ☐ Support
- ☐ Acceptance
- ☐ Reflection
- ☐ Goal-Setting
- ☐ Action

4.3 The One Shift That Would Make the Most Difference

Looking at everything you have discovered — your resilience anchors, your adaptability edges, your optimism practice, your support network, your acceptance, your reflections, your goal, your action blockers — what is the single most important shift you need to make?

Not a list. One thing. The one shift:

4.4 What You Notice

Are there patterns across the eight dimensions? Do your stronger areas support each other? Do your development areas cluster around a common theme? Write freely for a few minutes:

A note on self-knowledge during setbacks

There is a particular way that a setback distorts self-knowledge. In the weeks and months after loss, we often score ourselves against the person we were before, not the person we actually are in the middle of the loss. If your answers surprised you — if you seem stronger or weaker than you expected — sit with that surprise before moving on. The most dangerous moment is not when you admit you are struggling. It is when you convince yourself you are fine, when in fact you have simply become very skilled at performing fine for an audience that includes yourself.

BOUNCING FORWARD

The Snapshot asked you to do something that sounds simple and is not: looking at the whole picture at once. Not one dimension examined in isolation, but all eight together — and to name, in a single sentence, the one shift that matters most.

If that answer was difficult to arrive at, the difficulty is information. The things that are hardest to name clearly are usually the things most worth naming.

What you have in front of you now is not a diagnosis. It is a map. Maps don’t tell you where to go — they show you where you are, so that whatever direction you choose next, you are choosing it deliberately. A map is only useful when you begin to move.

Part Five
YOUR PERSONAL
ACTION PLAN
Where what you have discovered
becomes what you will do

Everything you’ve discovered now becomes something you commit to. Be as specific as you can. The more specific you are, the more useful this plan will be. A vague intention dissolves under pressure. A named commitment holds.

5.1 My Two Focus Areas

Based on your snapshot, which two dimensions deserve the most attention right now?

- ☐ Resilience
- ☐ Adaptability
- ☐ Optimism
- ☐ Support
- ☐ Acceptance
- ☐ Reflection
- ☐ Goal-Setting
- ☐ Action

5.2 Why I Think I Score Low Here

What patterns or habits do you notice that explain why these areas are harder for you right now?

5.3 My Three Specific Actions in the Next 30 Days

Not general intentions — specific actions. Name what you will do, when, and with whom if relevant.

Action 1:

Action 2:

Action 3:

5.4 The Person I Will Ask for Support

Name one person who can support your journey through this. Be specific about what you will ask them for — not ‘support’ in the abstract, but something concrete.

Their name:

What I will ask them for:

5.5 My Goal and Whose Face Is Attached to It

My goal:

What I will ask them for:

5.6 How I Will Measure Progress in 90 Days

Not whether you have arrived — but what will be true in 90 days that is not true today, if you begin?

5.7 My Timeline

I will take my first action:

- ☐ Today — within the next hour
- ☐ This week
- ☐ This month

Three keys to keeping your plan alive

Review and adapt regularly — your circumstances will change, and your plan should change with them. Flexibility is not weakness; it is intelligence applied to an uncertain world. Acknowledge every success, regardless of size. Each acknowledgment reinforces your dedication to the journey and builds the momentum that carries you forward. Return to this workbook. Not as a completed document, but as an ongoing companion. Your answers will change. Let them.

You have just done something that most people — even those in the middle of loss, even those who have done all the reflection and self-examination — find genuinely hard. You have moved from knowing to committing. You have named specific actions, a specific person, a specific goal, a specific measure of progress. That is not the same as wanting to do those things. It is a different order of things entirely.

The gap between insight and commitment is where most journeys stall. You have crossed it. What you have written here is not a finished plan — life will adjust it, and it should be adjusted. But it is a named direction, and named directions carry a particular kind of weight. They pull toward themselves when you act on them, and they quietly ask something of you when you don’t.

Hold what you’ve written — not as a standard to meet perfectly, but as the commitment you made to yourself today, in this section, at this moment, carrying what you are carrying. That is enough to begin.

Part Six

FULL SELF-ASSESSMENT

40 questions across all eight dimensions

Answer instinctively — your first response is usually more honest than your considered one. Answer as you are right now, not as you were before the loss or hope to be. A lower score is not a judgment. It is useful information about where your most important work lies.

Scoring: A = 1 point | B = 2 points | C = 3 points

Your score in each section: 5–8 = this is where your most important work lies | 9–11 = real foundations with specific places to strengthen | 12–15 = a genuine resource

Section 1: Resilience

1. When facing a significant challenge, how do you usually respond?

A. I feel overwhelmed and struggle to find a way forward.

B. I manage to keep going, but it takes me some time to adapt.

C. I quickly find ways to adapt and view challenges as opportunities to grow.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
2. Think about a time when you experienced failure. What was your immediate thought process?

A. I doubted my abilities and felt like giving up.

B. I felt disappointed, but I was open to understanding what went wrong.

C. I quickly find ways to adapt and view challenges as opportunities to grow.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
3. How do you view the statement ‘What doesn’t kill you makes you stronger’?

A. It sounds unrealistic and overly optimistic.

B. It can be true in some situations, but not always.

C. I strongly believe in it and see challenges as a way to strengthen myself.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

4. How often do you reflect on past hardships with a sense of growth or gratitude?

- A. Rarely — I tend to focus on the negative aspects.
- B. Sometimes — I can see how some difficulties have helped me grow.
- C. Often — I believe past hardships have shaped who I am today.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. When you think about the future and potential obstacles, how do you feel?

- A. Anxious and worried about what might go wrong.
- B. Cautious but hopeful that I can handle what comes.
- C. Confident and prepared to face and overcome challenges.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Resilience Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: You are carrying a great deal right now, and real resilience takes time to build. Go back to the Resilience section and look for one practice you can begin this week. Not a plan. One small, honest thing.

9–11: You have been through difficulty before and you have come through. The questions where you scored lower are telling you something worth hearing — these are the specific places where setbacks find the edges of your resilience.

12–15: This is a genuine strength, and it has been tested. The question worth asking now is not how you maintain it, but how you use it — how the resilience you have built can serve not only you, but those around you who are still in the middle of theirs.

Section 2: Adaptability

1. When confronted with a sudden change in your plans, how do you react?

- A. I feel stressed and wish things would stay the same.
- B. I’m initially surprised, but I try to adjust as best I can.
- C. I quickly adapt, seeing it as an opportunity for something new.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

2. How do you approach learning a new skill or entering unfamiliar territory?

- A. With hesitation — I find it difficult and sometimes unnecessary.
- B. Cautiously — I understand its importance but might struggle to start.
- C. With enthusiasm — I’m eager to learn and integrate new things into my life.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

3. Consider a time when your usual way of doing things didn’t work. What did you do?

- A. I kept trying the same method, hoping it would eventually work.
- B. I sought advice but was hesitant to depart too far from what I knew.
- C. I innovated, exploring entirely new approaches until I found a solution.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

4. How do you feel about the statement ‘Change is the only constant’?

- A. It’s unsettling — I prefer stability and predictability.
- B. It’s a challenging idea, but I see some truth in it.
- C. I fully agree and accept change as a natural part of life.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. When thinking about the future, how do you prepare for unforeseen changes?

- A. I worry about them but don’t actively prepare much.
- B. I make some plans but stick mostly to what I know.
- C. I actively seek varied experiences and skills to better adapt to future changes.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Adaptability Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: Setbacks ask us to become someone we did not plan to be, in a world we did not plan to inhabit. It is entirely natural to resist this. Return to the Adaptability section as a reminder that adapting after loss is not a betrayal of who you were — it is how you survive.

9–11: You are more capable of adapting than your lower-scoring questions suggest. Look at the specific questions where you scored lower and ask honestly: is this a permanent limitation, or a temporary contraction caused by what you are carrying right now?

12–15: Adaptability is working for you. The one thing worth checking is that your capacity to adapt quickly is serving your healing, not helping you move past things before you have properly sat with them.

Section 3: Optimism

1. When faced with a difficult situation, how do you usually perceive it?

- A. As mostly negative, with little hope for a positive outcome.
- B. With a mix of optimism and realism, looking for a silver lining.
- C. As an opportunity for growth, focusing on the positive aspects.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

2. How do you react to setbacks in your personal or professional life?

- A. I tend to dwell on what went wrong and worry about the future.
- B. I feel disappointed but try to find lessons in the experience.
- C. I quickly shift my focus to recovery and new opportunities.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

3. What goes through your mind when you hear about a future challenge or obstacle?

- A. Concern and doubt about my ability to handle it.
- B. Curiosity about how I might tackle it, mixed with some apprehension.
- C. Confidence that I will find a way to overcome it.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

4. How do you feel about the saying ‘Every cloud has a silver lining’?

- A. It seems overly idealistic and not always true.
- B. It’s a nice thought, but sometimes hard to believe in tough situations.
- C. I strongly believe in it and always look for the positive in every situation.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. When planning for the future, how do you envision your path forward?

- A. I worry about the potential problems and obstacles that might arise
- B. I am hopeful but cautious, preparing for both good and bad outcomes.
- C. I am optimistic about achieving my goals and overcoming any challenges.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Optimism Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: Finding optimism difficult after a significant loss is not a character flaw. It is an honest response to an honest situation. Optimism, as this workbook understands it, is not a feeling. It is a decision you can make even in the dark. You do not have to feel it to practise it. Start with observation.

9–11: You have the capacity for optimism, but setbacks have made it harder to access right now. That is very common and very human. Look at the questions where you scored lower — they usually touch the places your particular loss has reached most deeply.

12–15: Genuine optimism — the kind that coexists with setbacks rather than denying them — is a powerful thing. What you have here can sustain not only you but people around you who are struggling to find their own way through.

Section 4: Support

1. When you encounter a major challenge or setback, whom do you turn to first?

- A. I prefer to deal with issues on my own — reaching out to others is difficult.
- B. I might discuss it with one or two close individuals, but I hesitate to share broadly.
- C. I openly seek advice and comfort from a wide circle of family, friends, or community.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

2. How do you feel about asking for help when you need it?

- A. Uncomfortable — I see it as a sign of weakness.
- B. It’s okay for serious matters, though I generally try to solve problems myself.
- C. Comfortable — I view asking for help as a strength and a natural part of life.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

3. Reflect on a time you offered support to someone else. How did it make you feel?

- A. Unsure — I’m not confident in my ability to help others.
- B. Good, but I worry about overstepping or not being helpful enough.
- C. Empowered and fulfilled — helping others is important to me.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

4. How connected do you feel to your community?

- A. Isolated — I struggle to feel a sense of belonging.
- B. Somewhat connected, but there’s a barrier to feeling fully integrated.
- C. Very connected — I actively engage and feel a strong sense of belonging.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. What role do support networks play in your approach to overcoming obstacles?

- A. Minimal — I primarily rely on my own resources and resilience.
- B. Supplemental — they’re helpful, but not my main means of dealing with challenges.
- C. Central — my support network is integral to my action and recovery process.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Optimism Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: Setbacks have a way of making us feel that our pain is too much to ask others to bear — and so we carry it alone at the very moment when connection matters most. The invitation is a simple one: let one person in. Not everyone. One person, with one honest conversation. Begin there.

9–11: You understand, at some level, that support matters — but something makes it difficult to receive fully. It may be the fear of being a burden, or uncertainty about what to ask for. Look at the specific questions where you scored lower. They usually reveal the particular form that difficulty takes for you.

12–15: You give and receive support naturally, and that is a rare thing. The question worth asking now is whether what flows in matches what flows out — or whether, in your instinct to care for others, you have been neglecting to let others care for you.

Section 5: Acceptance

1. When confronted with a significant life challenge, how do you typically respond initially?

- A. I avoid thinking about it and hope it resolves on its own.
- B. I acknowledge it, but it takes me time to fully accept the reality.
- C. I confront it head-on, accepting the reality of the situation from the start.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

2. How do you deal with negative emotions that arise from difficult situations?

- A. I try to suppress or ignore them, hoping they’ll eventually go away.
- B. I recognise them, but struggle to fully process or accept them.
- C. I allow myself to feel and understand these emotions as a step toward dealing with the situation.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

3. Reflecting on past hardships, how do you view your initial acceptance of those situations?

- A. I often remained in denial, finding it hard to accept the truth.
- B. I eventually came to terms with reality, though it took time.
- C. I quickly moved toward acceptance, understanding its importance for my progress.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

4. In moments of hardship, how do you view the act of acknowledging and accepting the situation?

- A. It’s challenging to see how accepting a difficult reality can lead to personal growth.
- B. I understand the importance of acceptance for growth, though it’s not always easy to practise.
- C. I firmly believe in the power of acceptance as a foundation for personal development.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. When thinking about acceptance in the context of personal growth, which statement resonates most?
- A. It’s challenging to see how accepting a difficult reality can lead to personal growth.
 - B. I understand the importance of acceptance for growth, though it’s not always easy to practise.
 - C. I firmly believe in the power of acceptance as a foundation for personal development.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Optimism Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: Acceptance cannot be rushed, and if you scored here, it may simply mean that your loss is still too close, too raw, for acceptance to feel possible yet. That is not a problem to solve — it is a stage of the journey. Return to the Acceptance section with compassion rather than pressure.

9–11: You are somewhere in the middle of this work — which is, honestly, where most people are. Acceptance tends to arrive in waves rather than all at once. The questions where you scored lower are worth sitting with: what, specifically, is hardest for you to accept?

12–15: Acceptance is a foundation you have built. That does not mean the setback is resolved — it means you are carrying it rather than fighting it. The work now is to ensure that acceptance does not shade into resignation: there is a difference between carrying something and being defined by it.

Section 6: Reflection

1. How often do you set aside time for self-reflection?
- A. Rarely — I don’t spend much time thinking about my past actions or experiences.
 - B. Occasionally — I reflect now and then, especially on significant events.
 - C. Regularly — I make it a point to introspect and evaluate my experiences frequently.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
2. After facing a challenge, what is your approach to understanding what happened?
- A. I tend to move on without much thought, focusing on the future rather than the past.
 - B. I think about what happened and talk it over with someone, but don’t dig too deep.
 - C. I deeply analyse the situation, my reactions, and what I can learn from it.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
3. How do you view mistakes and failures in your life?
- A. Mostly as negative experiences that I prefer to forget.
 - B. As unfortunate but inevitable parts of life, though I struggle to find value in them.
 - C. As valuable learning opportunities that contribute significantly to my personal growth.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
4. When considering your personal growth, how important is self-reflection to you?
- A. Not very — I believe growth happens more through external experiences than internal reflection.
 - B. Somewhat important — I see its value but don’t prioritise it as much as I perhaps should.
 - C. Essential — I view self-reflection as a critical component of my growth and development.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. How do you react when feedback or experiences challenge your self-perception?
- A. With resistance — I find it hard to accept views that differ significantly from my own.
 - B. With openness, but it takes me time to integrate this new information.
 - C. With eagerness — I appreciate the opportunity to gain new insights into myself and grow.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Reflection Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: The instinct to keep moving — to avoid the stillness that reflection requires — is one of the most common responses to loss. The suggestion is not a structured journaling practice. It is this: at the end of one day this week, sit quietly for ten minutes and ask yourself one question. What did I feel today? Nothing more than that. Begin there.

9–11: You reflect, but perhaps not as regularly or as deeply as would serve you right now. Try to notice when you instinctively move past something, and choose instead to stay with it a little longer.

12–15: Reflection is already a practice for you. The invitation at this score is to move from reflection as review to reflection as genuine inquiry — not just what happened, but what does this ask of me? That second question is where reflection becomes transformation.

Section 7: Goal-Setting

1. How do you typically identify new goals for yourself?
- A. I rarely set specific goals — I tend to go with the flow and see what happens.
 - B. I set goals based on what seems reasonable or expected of me by others.
 - C. I reflect on my passions and long-term vision to set goals that truly resonate with me.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
2. When you think about your goals, how do they relate to your personal development?
- A. I haven’t thought much about how my goals connect to my personal growth.
 - B. Some of my goals are related to my development, but it’s not a consistent focus.
 - C. My goals are closely aligned with my personal development and represent what I strive for.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
3. How do you approach planning to achieve your goals?
- A. I don’t usually make specific plans — I prefer to tackle things as they come.
 - B. I make a general plan but often find it hard to stick to the specifics.
 - C. I create detailed plans with actionable steps and regularly review and adjust them.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
4. How does setting new goals make you feel about your future?
- A. Overwhelmed or uncertain — it’s hard to know where to start.
 - B. Motivated, but I sometimes doubt my ability to achieve the goals I set.
 - C. Excited and focused — setting goals gives me clear direction and confidence.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. How often do you review and adjust your goals based on your progress or life changes?
- A. Rarely, if ever — once I set a goal, I don’t tend to change it much.
 - B. Occasionally, but I could probably do it more systematically.
 - C. Regularly — I understand the importance of adapting my goals to reflect current reality.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Goal-Setting Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: After loss, the idea of goals can feel premature — even inappropriate. That feeling is worth honouring. But a goal does not have to be large or distant to be useful. It can simply be a direction: something small and meaningful that gives the next day a shape. Start with one thing.

9–11: You understand the value of goals but something — uncertainty, setbacks, shifting circumstances — makes it difficult to hold them steadily. Look at your lower-scoring questions not as weaknesses but as honest edges — the places where your capacity for forward movement currently reach, and from which it can grow.

12–15: Goal-setting is a genuine strength. The deeper question at this score is not whether your goals are clear, but whether they are still connected to what matters most — whether someone you love is attached to what you are building.

Section 8: Action

1. When you have set a goal, how do you start working toward it?
- A. I often wait for the right moment or feel hesitant to start.
 - B. I make a plan but sometimes delay taking the first step.
 - C. I take immediate action, even if it’s small, to build momentum.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
2. How do you react when encountering unexpected changes while pursuing your goals?
- A. I feel discouraged and consider giving up.
 - B. I’m cautious and take time to adjust my plans.
 - C. I view it as an opportunity to learn and adapt my approach.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
3. What is your attitude toward stepping out of your comfort zone?
- A. I avoid it as much as possible — it feels too risky.
 - B. I’m cautious but willing to try if it seems necessary.
 - C. I embrace it — I believe growth comes from new challenges.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)
4. How often do you review your actions to ensure they align with your goals?
- A. Rarely — I tend to stick to the plan without much adjustment.
 - B. Occasionally, when I remember to or when there’s an obvious need.
 - C. Regularly — I consistently evaluate and adjust my approach as needed.
- Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

5. Reflecting on your journey, how has embracing change contributed to your personal development?

- A. I find change uncomfortable and generally try to maintain stability.
- B. I've slowly started to see the value of change, though it's often challenging.
- C. Embracing change has been crucial to my growth — it has opened up new paths and opportunities.

Score: ☐ A (1pt) ☐ B (2pts) ☐ C (3pts)

Action Total Score: _____ / 15

Score guide

5–8: If beginning feels impossible right now, that is the setback talking — and the setback is not wrong. But there is a difference between resting and being frozen. Return to the Taking Action section and ask yourself: what is the smallest possible first step? Something that takes ten minutes or less. Often the act of taking it, however small, begins to loosen what felt immovable.

9–11: You know how to begin and you know how to keep going — but sustaining action through setbacks and uncertainty is harder than it looks. The questions where you scored lower often point to the specific conditions under which your momentum falters. Name those conditions honestly. Knowing where you tend to stop is the first step toward not stopping there.

12–15: You are someone who acts, and that is a gift. What matters now is that your action remains connected to its source. Revisit the purpose beneath the plan. You should be building something, not simply staying busy. The doing must serve the meaning, not replace it.

Fill in your totals below to see the full picture:

Dimension	My Score	What this means
Resilience	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Adaptability	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Optimism	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Support	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Acceptance	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Reflection	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Goal-Setting	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15
Action	/15	5-8/ 9-11/ 12-15

You’ve answered forty questions—across eight dimensions, across the compass and the path—as honestly as you could on this particular day. That is a significant act of self-examination.

The scores are not a verdict. They are a reading, taken at a specific moment, by a person in a specific chapter of their life. Return to this assessment in six months and your scores will almost certainly have shifted. That shift will not mean you succeeded or failed. It will mean you moved.

If you came to this assessment before working through the earlier sections, take your two lowest-scoring dimensions back to those sections now. The assessment has given you a map. The earlier sections are where you learn to read it.

If you worked through the sections first and have come here to go deeper, use these scores to sharpen what you already know. Where did the assessment confirm what you discovered in yourself? Where did it surprise you? Surprises are usually worth staying with—they are the places where self-knowledge is still forming.

Part Seven

CLOSING PROGRESS CHECK-IN

Return to these pages at 30 and 90 days

This workbook is not a document to complete once and put aside. It is an ongoing companion. The pages below are designed for you to return to at 30 days and again at 90 days — to take your temperature, notice what has shifted, and renew your commitment.

30-Day Check-In

Date:_____

My energy right now:

- ☐ Low
- ☐ Building
- ☐ Steady
- ☐ Strong

One thing that has genuinely shifted since I started this workbook:

One thing that is still difficult:

The action I am most proud of taking:

My adjusted focus for the next 30 days:

Acknowledge this moment

You came back. That matters. Whatever you have or have not done since you first opened this workbook, the fact that you are here, checking in, means you have not stopped. That is not a small thing. That is the whole of what Bouncing Forward asks of you.

This workbook is not a document to complete once and put aside. It is an ongoing companion. The pages below are designed for you to return to at 30 days and again at 90 days — to take your temperature, notice what has shifted, and renew your commitment.

90-Day Check-In

Date:_____

My energy right now:

- ☐ Low
- ☐ Building
- ☐ Steady
- ☐ Strong

What is true today that was not true 90 days ago?

My goal 90 days ago was:

How far I have come toward it:

The next chapter I am moving into:

One person I want to thank for supporting my journey:

From here

The road before you is yours to define. You have the compass. You have the path. You have, if you have worked honestly through these pages, a clearer sense of where you stand and where you are going.

Bounce forward. Not back to who you were before the storm. Forward to who you are when you have crossed it.

Your Decision

Circle the one that feels true right now:

- ☐ I am not ready yet
- ☐ I am starting to consider change
- ☐ I am ready to move forward
- ☐ I am already moving forward

My Commitment

Complete this sentence, in your own words:

“I choose to move forward by...

The road before you is yours to define.

You have the compass. You have the path.

Go forward.

— Maher Kaddoura

www.maherkaddoura.com